

Dvar Torah Outline — Parashat Bereishit: Adam HaRishon, Teshuvah, “Attiyo Shel Nachash,” and Our Relationship to Physicality

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman addresses a foundational question raised by Rav Tzadok: if Adam HaRishon and Chavah did teshuvah after the sin of the Tree of Knowledge, why was the decree of death not removed? Rabbi Shulman explains that the sin did not merely add a punishable misdeed; it permanently altered humanity's relationship to physical pleasure by introducing “attiyo shel nachash,” a gravitational pull toward the external, sensory side of life. The dvar Torah frames this struggle with desire as a defining axis of human development, suggests that only תחיית המתים can fully repair it, and closes with a practical charge to sanctify “permitted” daily actions—especially through the training ground of shabbat.

I. Rav Tzadok's question: why doesn't teshuvah remove the decree of death?

A. The difficulty in Bereishit's narrative

- Adam HaRishon sins and receives a decree of **מיתה**.
- Rabbi Shulman notes Rav Tzadok's question: since Chazal indicate **Adam and Chavah did teshuvah**, why does the decree remain?

B. Teshuvah's power seems to contradict the outcome

- Rabbi Shulman cites the principle: **גדולה תשובה שמקרעת גזר דינו של אדם**.
- Additional reason the question is sharper:
 - Adam HaRishon is not merely an individual; he represents the **collective root of humanity**.
 - Rav Tzadok argues he should have the standing of a **ציבור**, which is especially receptive to forgiveness through teshuvah.

C. Core question

- If teshuvah can tear up a decree, and Adam has the status of a ציבור, **why is the decree of death not rescinded?**
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II. Rav Tzadok's answer: "attiyo shel nachash" as a permanent change in human nature (2:01)

A. The introduction of "attiyo shel nachash"

- Rabbi Shulman explains Rav Tzadok's idea: eating from עץ הדעת טוב ורע introduced עטיו של נחש ("the serpent's poison").

B. What the "poison" means (not magical—psychological/spiritual)

- Rabbi Shulman clarifies: it is the תאוה element—
 - the pull toward **pleasure-for-itself**,
 - a self-centered enjoyment of the physical that **draws a person away from Hashem**.

C. Analogy: knowing pleasure vs. being driven by pleasure

- Rabbi Shulman compares it to an "AI agent" that can describe what is delicious but does not *crave* it.
 - The "poison" is precisely **being drawn after** physical pleasure, not merely recognizing it.
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III. "ואוכל" in ongoing tense: Adam's new relationship to eating (4:00)

A. A puzzling Midrash reading

- Rabbi Shulman highlights a Midrashic inference:
 - Adam says: she gave me, ואוכל—read not only as "I ate," but as "**I eat**" (ongoing).

B. The challenge

- If Adam did teshuvah (as brought in Zohar/Midrash), how can he speak as though the act continues?

C. Rav Tzadok's resolution

- Rabbi Shulman explains: Adam means that **from that point onward**, every act of eating is altered.
 - Eating from עץ הדעת rewired the experience of food:
 - now, whenever he eats, he is **re-living** (to some degree) attachment to the עץ הדעת dynamic—clinging to externals and physical gratification.
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IV. Rabbi Shulman's expansion: two “central trees” as two life-forces in all experience (6:00)

A. Reading the pesukim conceptually

- Rabbi Shulman proposes: the Torah's phrasing suggests both
 - עץ החיים
 - and עץ הדעת טוב ורע were בתוך הגן—central in the Garden.

B. Two root-orientations that spread into everything else

- Rabbi Shulman suggests these two trees represent two foundational “channels” present throughout all creation in the garden:
 - עץ החיים: inner meaning, closeness to Hashem, פנימיות :
 - עץ הדעת: externals, the surface-level experience of things, חיצוניות :

C. “Taste” of all other foods changes based on which root was chosen

- If Adam had eaten from עץ החיים first, then all later eating would taste the פנימיות.
 - Because Adam ate from עץ הדעת, subsequent eating becomes **definitionally** tied to externals and physicality.
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V. How the Midrash's multiple identifications of the Tree of Knowledge can all be true (8:00)

A. The classic Midrashic debate

- Rabbi Shulman lists the Midrash's opinions:
 - חיטה, תאנה, גפן, אתרוג.
- The Midrash asserts: אלו ואלו דברי אלקים חיים—all are true.

B. Why “all true” is plausible if the Tree is a central spiritual concept

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - Adam and Chavah lived in a radically higher reality (citing Ramchal in דעת תבונות: their bodies were on a spiritual plane unlike ours).
 - The “fruit” in the center is not a simple botanical item we can identify today.

C. Maharal’s “central point spreads in four directions”

- Rabbi Shulman applies the Maharal’s principle:
 - a central מרכזית נקודה expands into multiple expressions.
 - Therefore:
 - wheat, grapevine, fig, and etrog can each be a different “branch-expression” of the core עץ הדעת concept.
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VI. Why death remains: the sin changed what humanity *is*, not merely what humanity *did* (10:01)

A. Not just a punishable עבירה, but an ontological shift

- Rabbi Shulman: Adam’s reality became fundamentally connected to **physicality**.

B. Maharal’s principle: physicality implies decay

- Rabbi Shulman invokes the Maharal:
 - physical things are subject to העדר (decay/cessation),
 - spiritual/abstract realities are not.

C. The timing matters: this is embedded in creation itself

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes:
 - this occurs within **the sixth day of creation**—part of humanity’s “blueprint.”
 - It becomes “DNA-level”: an enduring structural feature of human life.

D. Therefore, the fix is not simple forgiveness

- Rabbi Shulman concludes:
 - the decree cannot simply be “erased” like later sins might be.
 - Full repair requires תחיית המתים.
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VII. Even great tzaddikim: Yaakov Avinu and “mitah shel nachash” (12:30)

A. “Everything is relative,” yet a person can transcend greatly

- Rabbi Shulman notes that one can be **relatively transcendent** from physical pull.

B. Yaakov’s struggle reflects minimal vulnerability

- Rabbi Shulman interprets the angel wrestling with Yaakov:
 - the angel sought a flaw and found only in the “hip area,” which Rav Tzadok reads as the realm of physical intimacy.
- Even with holy intent (להוליד בנים, building the twelve tribes), there can be a tiny residue of physical pleasure.

C. Two truths about Yaakov

- On one level: Yaakov dies physically.
- On another: **יעקב אבינו לא מת** (Gemara Ta’anit) — spiritually, he is not bound to cravings.

D. “Mitah shel nachash” even without sin

- Rabbi Shulman references the idea (Gemara Shabbat) of four who never sinned yet died **מיתה של נחש**:
 - even the most righteous cannot entirely escape the post-sin human condition.

VIII. The struggle with desire as a central axis of human development (15:00)

A. Maharal: the 7 mitzvot of בני נח map human life-categories

- Rabbi Shulman cites the Maharal’s structure:
 - 3 mitzvot בין אדם למקום
 - 3 mitzvot בין אדם לחברו
 - 1 mitzvah (אבר מן החי) addresses **control of physical desire**.

B. Why that last one matters

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - the first human failure point was in **תאוות / desire**.

- that is where the יצר הרע characteristically enters.

C. “אכלתי ואוכל” as the human condition

- Rabbi Shulman frames Adam’s phrase as timeless:
 - we continue to “eat from” the עץ הדעת dynamic daily.
 - more attachment to it → more “mortal” orientation;
 - more transcendence → closer to the level of Yaakov’s “לא מת” and Adam before the sin.
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IX. Practical takeaways: sanctifying the “average actions” and using shabbat as training (16:00)

A. The avodah: “permitted but not l’shem shamayim”

- Rabbi Shulman points to a growth area:
 - מעשים בינוניים—actions that are technically permitted but not necessarily elevated.

B. Shabbat as a launching pad

- Rabbi Shulman closes with shabbat as a concrete framework to sanctify physicality:
 - eating and enjoyment can be infused with gratitude and recognition of Hashem’s blessings.
 - this becomes training for a week of clinging more to עץ החיים than to עץ הדעת טוב ורע.
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X. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman presents Rav Tzadok’s question: why Adam’s teshuvah did not cancel the decree of death.
- He explains “עטיו של נחש” as the human compulsion toward physical pleasure and externals—an identity-level change, not just a punishable act.
- He reframes the Midrashic debates about the Tree’s species as multiple manifestations of one central spiritual root-concept.
- He shows how even great tzaddikim reflect the lingering human condition, while also modeling relative transcendence.
- He concludes with practical avodah: elevate everyday permitted actions, with shabbat serving as the primary training ground to reconnect to עץ החיים.